



YOU ARE **12 WEEKS AND 2 DAYS**

194 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

In this ultrasound scan, the baby is seen floating in amniotic fluid, which provides plenty of space for him to move around. Later in pregnancy, your baby will excrete waste products into the fluid, but his bladder is still tiny and kidney function not yet established.

“The bag of amniotic fluid is your baby’s home—it will keep him safe and free from infection until he is ready to be born.”

Your baby is safely cushioned in the amniotic fluid, which gives space for them to move and grow and helps them maintain a constant temperature.

The volume of amniotic fluid is only 1 ml at seven weeks but is 25 ml by this stage of your pregnancy. In about six weeks’ time, there will be around 60 ml of fluid, with plenty of room for your baby to move around and to do lots of somersaults.

The amniotic fluid increases steadily until around 32 weeks of pregnancy, then stays constant until 37 weeks. It begins to reduce slightly thereafter by about 8 percent per week.

Further on in the pregnancy, waste products excreted in your baby’s urine will be absorbed from the fluid back into your bloodstream. At 37 weeks, a baby urinates an astonishing one-quarter to one-third of his body weight every day. Compare this with your own production of 2–3 percent body weight as urine.

Your temperature directly influences your baby’s temperature. Temperature control is not an important requirement until later in pregnancy when your baby’s high metabolic rate means that heat needs to be transferred to you in order to cool down.

IRON-RICH FOODS

Anemia is fairly common in pregnancy and is more likely to occur when you start pregnancy with low iron reserves. This can be because you became pregnant unexpectedly, had a baby in the last 18 months, have had very heavy periods, or don’t eat any red meat or fish. While you can’t undo these, you can start to increase your intake of iron-rich foods. Anemia in pregnancy can influence not only the size of your placenta, but could increase your risk of giving birth prematurely or to a smaller baby.

ASK A NUTRITIONIST

My appetite has come back, but how many calories should I be eating at this stage of my pregnancy? Like many women, you’re finding that the second trimester has brought relief from